

Zeitenwende and Continuity: What Germany's Defence Spending Surge Reveals About Its Foreign Policy

Abstract

Germany's increase in defence spending was simply caused by a realist response to Russian aggression, revealing more about how Germany understands its role in the international system. Combining this realist with constructivist and regional-security perspectives, it traces a shift in Germany's perception of the international system, from a broadly cooperative to an increasingly adversarial reading of anarchy, alongside its emerging self-image as Europe's security guarantor. It concludes that this represents external change in German foreign policy, but continuity in the multilateral strategic culture underpinning it.

Introduction

The announcement of the *Zeitenwende* by Chancellor Olaf Scholz (Scholz 2022a) after Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine signified a shift in Germany's foreign policy. This surge in spending has implications beyond a neorealist conception of defence, leading to focus towards EU integration, due to collective security dependence and regional leadership, and a shift in Germany's perception of the international system and its position in it, but limited domestic change in its strategic culture.

Defensive neorealism serves as a basis to understand a surge in defence spending, where state action is driven by survival and expansion causes counterbalancing from other states. Focusing on the distribution of capabilities is critical for state survival, as it determines their position in the international system and triggers counterbalancing, which internally relies on defence spending and strengthening military capabilities (Waltz 1979, 116-128).

Regionalism adds another level of analysis, as it offers insight into the analysis of states' collective action. This collective decision-making is made stronger in regions with high degrees of institutionalisation (Barbieri 2019, 427), where states are influenced by collective preferences and identities. Therefore, regions are effectively a primary unit of analysis for security rather than the state.

Strategic culture and constructivism offer a foundational understanding for foreign policy by introducing the significance of identity, a basis for the self-perception of states and the state's perception of others and the international system.

For constructivists, meaning is created and reproduced through socialisation (Hopf 1998, 178), which is at the basis of identity formation. Depending on how they understand their position in the system and their perception of others, they will see the international system in a different manner. Therefore, as Alexander Wendt argues, "anarchy is what states make of it" (Wendt 1992), taking Hobbesian, Kantian, and Lockean forms, based on enmity, amity and rivalry with other countries respectively, depending on perceptions (Wendt 1999). How a state perceives itself in the system is significant, as the identity it attributes itself will also drive its actions. This can even be applied at the regional level where states can undertake diverse roles, like civilian or military powers, which utilise different tools based on this. Strategic culture will complete this framework by including internal processes of identity formation. Strategic culture assumes that culture informs decision-makers because they are cultural agents, largely influencing state identity and, consequently, foreign policy. This logic can also apply to regions, as regions have unique identities that complement their national identities, leading to collective foreign policy.

The rest of this analysis traces both dynamics in Germany's case: real shifts in how it sees its position in the world, alongside a domestic identity that has proven far more durable.

Empirical analysis

The surge in German defence spending implies a shift in the country's perception of its position in the international system. Post-Cold War, Germany has neglected the Bundeswehr (Mölling et al. 2023) because it has been surrounded by allies (Bagger 2019) and further supported by NATO, particularly the US. Nevertheless, both Russian aggressions created external pressures that triggered the surge in defence spending. Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014 was taken by Germany as an initial threat but the invasion of Ukraine in 2022 and halting gas deliveries through the Nord Stream pipelines signified a complete breakdown of its collaborative relationship. These triggered the announcement of the *Zeitenwende*, an increase in defence spending and a severance of ties with Russia (Scholz 2022a). Neorealism offers a partial explanation: Russia's expansionism and military build-up shifted the distribution of capabilities in Europe, which triggered counterbalancing by European states. However, this explanation cannot explain why Germany failed to increase its spending after 2014. Instead, constructivism shows how Germany went from perceiving the anarchical structure of the international system as Kantian to Lockean and signifying a possible shift towards Hobbesian anarchy. At the NATO summit in Wales in 2014 Germany stated that "Russia's aggressive actions against Ukraine have fundamentally challenged our vision of a Europe whole, free, and at peace" (NATO 2014), exemplifying a shift from Kantian to Lockean anarchy. Building on the *Zeitenwende*, the publication of the National Security Strategy in 2023 (Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development [BMZ] 2023), for the first time since the Cold War (Kamp 2023, 76), signifies a movement towards a feeling of bigger insecurity and enmity towards Russia, thus showcasing possible steps towards a Hobbesian anarchical view. This change in Germany's understanding of the international system has led to a shift in its perception of its role. Indeed, it has shifted from perceiving itself as a civilian power to working towards becoming a military power by becoming the largest military spender within European NATO

countries, growing its expenditure by 24% (SIPRI 2026). Germany wants to become a “guarantor of European security” (Scholz 2022b), placing this at the top of its priorities in the NSS (BMZ 2023, 11).

Germany’s role as Ukraine’s second largest defence supplier (Gibadło and Tarociński 2025) would appear to contradict its tradition as a civilian power, where they restrained from using and transferring military force (Maull 2000, 92-96). Nevertheless, Germany’s strategic culture has remained continuous, maintaining its commitment to “multilateralism, institution-building and supranational integration” (Maull 2000, 68-73). The idea of antimilitarism institutionalised after the World Wars held weight when Germany was regaining trust amongst its allies, thus adopting a restrained security policy to ensure other states that it was not pursuing military supremacy again and ensuring the principle of “Never Again” (Bagger 2019). However, Germany’s Basic Law (Grundgesetz) never supported this antimilitarist view and instead has emphasized the need for multilateralism: Article 24 indeed highlights the significance of collective security and Article 26 only states that preparing for a war of aggression, not defence, is unconstitutional (Basic Law for the Federal Republic of Germany 1949, arts. 24–26). This makes the reluctant maintenance of defence state failure (Mölling et al. 2023), not a current change in strategic culture. Therefore, the increase in the scale of military spending could suggest cultural change, but the multilateral rather than unilateral framings of the *Zeitenwende* and the Grundgesetz suggest continuity.

From a regional perspective, the decision to increase defence spending was collective across the EU, with a common understanding that there had been an under-investment (EPRS 2025, 1) and countries like Poland even spending more than Germany (Ulatowski 2024). The movement towards further European integration, where states organised as a security complex sharing common threats, despite defence policy remaining a responsibility of member states (Cepparulo et al. 2025, 928), is an expression of this internal continuity. One can argue that the

decision was externally incentivised by growing uncertainty over the reliability of the US for security (Ganter 2023). However, its main driver was internal on the basis of identity. Countries like Germany see security as collective and “indivisible from that of [its] European partners and allies” (BMZ 2023, 13), as theorised by the RSCT, and by efficiency, where the Europeanization of defence allows states to develop economies of scale (Mölling et al. 2023). For Germany, this integration has also been linked to its self-perception as a European leader, as showcased by its adoption of the role of military power, thus viewing the Bundeswehr as a tool for this security policy (Kamp 2023, 78). Therefore, the increase in defence spending has remained in line with German identity and strategic culture, embracing multilateralism and the idea of “Never Alone” (Bagger 2019; Maull 2000, 67-8), which frames its security strategy as inherently collective, pushing it at the front of integration as a leader.

Overall, the surge in defence spending has implied a shift in Germany’s perception of the international system and in its position in the system itself, embracing its role as leader in European security which is strengthened by this security itself. These external changes contrast the internal continuity of Germany’s strategic culture.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Germany’s recent surge in defence spending has implied external change but internal continuity.

There has been a shift in Germany’s perception of the international system, with a move from a Kantian to a Hobbesian understanding of its anarchical structure as a response to Russia’s aggressions. Further instability within the international system, like Trump’s policies towards NATO, could signify a further move towards a Hobbesian system.

External pressures have also pushed Germany towards embracing its role of European leader by using the Bundeswehr as a collective security tool. Moreover, this role has embraced

regional integration through collective surges in defence spending, both due to identity and efficiency. Nevertheless, this surge has also implied continuity in Germany's strategic culture, as the country is finally adhering to its security commitments and further embracing the significance of multilateralism.

This case ultimately demonstrates that systemic shocks can change how a state perceives the international system, but their response is shaped by identity, which can be driven by internal, systemic and regional aspects.

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